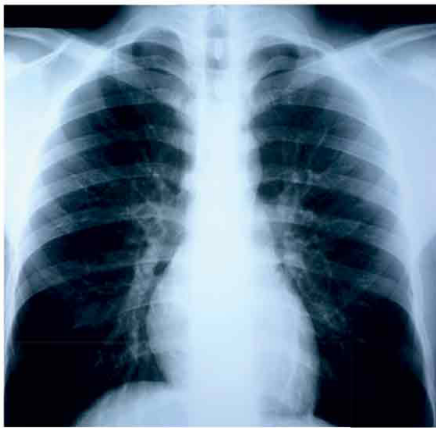


Looking inside

Years ago, the only way doctors could look inside a living body was by cutting it open. Today, they can use many different techniques to produce images of body organs and tissues without causing any harm. Some of the most common methods include X-rays, CT scans, MRI scans, and ultrasound.



X-ray

Discovered in 1895, X-rays are a form of high-energy radiation. These rays are beamed through the body onto a photographic film. Hard body parts, such as bones, absorb X-rays and show up clearly on film. X-rays pass through soft tissues, so these are less visible.

MRI scan

The scan below shows a cross-section through the head and was produced by magnetic resonance imaging (MRI). A person lies inside a tunnel-like scanner and is exposed to powerful magnets. This causes body tissues to give off radio waves, which the scanner's computer turns into images.

